

# Shashanka – Detailed Study Notes

## 1. Introduction

Shashanka was the first powerful independent king of ancient Bengal. He ruled during the 7th century AD, approximately from 600 to 637 AD. After the decline of the Gupta Empire, Bengal was divided into several small political regions. Shashanka united many of these regions and established the Kingdom of Gauda. Before becoming an independent ruler, he served as a Mahasamanta (a powerful feudatory chief). Later he declared independence and emerged as a strong ruler in eastern India. He established his capital at Karnasuvarna and expanded his influence across Bengal and neighboring regions.

## 2. Sources

The history of Shashanka is known from inscriptions, copper plates and literary works. These historical sources provide information about his administration, political activities and land grants.

Important inscriptions and copper plates:

- Midnapore inscription
- Egra inscription near Kharagpur
- Ganjam (Odisha) copper plate – dated 619 AD
- Banskhera copper plate of Harshavardhana
- Madhuvan copper plate
- Nidhanpur copper plate of Bhaskaravarman

Literary sources:

- Information from Bhaskaravarman
- Writings of Banabhatta
- Description of the Chinese traveler Xuanzang (Hiuen Tsang)
- Buddhist text Arya Manjushri Mulakalpa

## 3. Coins

Coins issued during the reign of Shashanka are important historical evidence. He issued gold and silver coins which contain royal titles and religious symbols. Some coins show symbols related to Lord Shiva, indicating that Shashanka followed Shaivism. These coins demonstrate the economic stability and political authority of his kingdom.

## 4. Capital

The capital of Shashanka's kingdom was Karnasuvarna. It was located near present-day Murshidabad in West Bengal. From this capital he controlled administration, military activities and the political affairs of his kingdom.

## **5. Area of the Kingdom**

The kingdom ruled by Shashanka was known as Gauda. His empire included most parts of Bengal along with regions of Odisha and parts of Bihar such as Magadha. His political influence also extended to Kongoda and nearby territories in eastern India.

## **6. Political Influence**

Shashanka was one of the most powerful rulers in northern India during the early 7th century. He was a contemporary of the famous ruler Harshavardhana and the king Bhaskaravarman of Kamarupa. During this period many political conflicts and alliances took place among regional rulers. Shashanka played an important role in these political events and strengthened the power of Gauda as a major state in eastern India.

## **7. Conclusion**

Shashanka was one of the earliest great rulers of Bengal. He united different regions and established a strong kingdom in the 7th century. His reign marked the rise of political power in eastern India. Information about his rule comes from inscriptions, copper plates, coins and literary texts. Because of his achievements, Shashanka occupies an important place in the history of Bengal and eastern India.